of forces against Pakistan, known as Operation Parakram. Tensions were further raised in May 2002, when the families of Indian soldiers—including ten children—were massacred by Pakistan-based militants at Kaluchak in Jammu and Kashmir. Although cross-border infiltrations from Pakistan continued, Musharraf informed US diplomats in June 2002 that they would decrease. India's military began to stand down from its mobilization in late 2002, due to the high costs, unwelcome international attention, and the presence of nuclear weapons on both sides, but having secured a notional commitment from Pakistan to stem cross-border terrorism. In November 2003, India and Pakistan agreed to a formal ceasefire along the International Border and Line of Control. [34]

Atomic Closure: Nuclear Diplomacy, 2004–2008

The post-Pokhran-II era witnessed a resolution of sorts: a civil nuclear agreement with the United States. Starting in the early 2000s, a small minority in the US government—concerned about the prospect of China's rise as a peer competitor to the United States—began to consider how best to facilitate India's rise as a balancer in Asia. India reciprocated: Vajpayee had called India and the United States 'natural allies' and after the 9/11 attacks discussions progressed on a variety of previously taboo topics such as ballistic missile defence cooperation and even the possibility of India sending peacekeepers to Iraq following the 2003 US invasion (a proposal that came remarkably close to fruition). [35] Even with a surprise change in government in India in 2004 from the BJP to a Congress-led United Progress Alliance (UPA) coalition, cooperation with the United States continued and accelerated with close coordination in relief efforts after the December 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami. [36] This early manifestation of cooperation among what became the Quad—India, Australia, Japan, and the United States—occurred despite strident opposition from India's communist parties, who were then supporting the Indian government.

The central hindrance in the burgeoning relationship between New Delhi and Washington was India's nuclear status, which ensured that it could not